



WEEK ONE · MODULE THREE

Ten Cases, and What They Test

Client empathy: reading what lies beneath the request

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

Work every case in writing, alone, before you open the debriefs. Reading first teaches you nothing at all.

Twelve minutes per case. Set a timer. In the house you will not have twelve minutes.

The debriefs are not answer keys. Several answers are defensible. What is not defensible is the absence of a method.

CHAPTER I

How to work a case

And why this is the hardest module of the week

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand what a case examines, and what it does not.

Adopt a repeatable method rather than an instinct.

A case in this profession is never a test of knowledge. You will not be asked which fork, or which vintage. You will be asked what you do at 21:04 on a Tuesday, with incomplete information, when the person who could clarify it is precisely the person you must not disturb.

What is being examined, in every case below, is **judgement under three constraints**: incomplete information, an unequal relationship, and the impossibility of asking too many questions. That triangle is the whole profession. Everything else is logistics.

Work them honestly. Write the answer you would actually give, not the answer that sounds professional. The distance between those two answers is exactly the distance you have left to travel, and the point of this module is to measure it while it is still cheap to do so.

CHAPTER II

The analytical framework

Five questions, in this order, every time

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Apply a repeatable five-step method to any request or incident.

Produce a defensible action, not a reaction.

Step	The question
1 · Read	What has actually been said, and what has been left out? Write the missing information down; do not fill it with assumption.
2 · Sources	What do I already possess that answers it? The diary. The preference file. The last time this happened. Almost every request is half-answered by a document you already hold.
3 · The need	What is the need beneath the request? Time, peace, or discretion, which of the three is at stake here? Name it explicitly.
4 · The people	Who signs, who decides, whose trust is at risk in this specific situation? Who else in the house is affected, and have they been told?
5 · The action	What do I do, in what order, and what single easy question, if any, remains for the principal? If my reply contains more than one question, I have not finished working.

THE DISCIPLINE

Every question you ask the principal is a small tax on their attention. Four questions is not diligence; it is an invoice for work you were paid to do.

The number of questions in your reply is your professional signature. Senior practitioners ask one, or none.

The ten cases

Do not read beyond this section until all ten are written.

Case I · The restaurant

21:04, Tuesday. The principal writes, in full: *“Do we still have that restaurant in Rome?”* Nothing else. No date, no restaurant, no number of guests.

- What do you do first, and what do you deliberately not do?
- Which documents already in your possession answer part of this?
- What exactly do you write back, and how many questions does your reply contain?

Case II · The contradiction

The principal asks you, directly, to book a villa in Sardinia for three weeks in August. Two days later the family office informs you that no discretionary expenditure above a threshold is approved this quarter, and that they were not consulted.

- Who is right?
- What do you do today, and in what channel?
- What must you never do, and why is it fatal?

Case III · The journalist

A courteous, well-informed caller says they are preparing a profile, that they already have most of the details, and that they need only to confirm the spelling of a name and whether the family still owns the house in the country.

- What do you say, word for word, in the moment?
- What do you do in the following ten minutes?
- Why is “I’ll have to check” a catastrophic answer?

Case IV · The empty house

A charming friend of the family, whom you have met at the house a dozen times, mentions in passing that they hear the family will be away in August, and asks warmly how long the house will be empty.

- Is this an innocent question, and does it matter whether it is?
- What do you answer?
- Does your familiarity with this person change anything? Be honest about what it does to your instinct.

Case V · The mistake

At 23:00 you discover that you have booked tomorrow morning's flight for the wrong day. The family are travelling with two children and a nanny.

- What is your first action, before any communication?
- When exactly do you tell them, and what are your opening two sentences?
- Which grammatical construction must not appear anywhere in your message, and why?

Case VI · The confidence

Late one evening, tired and unusually open, the principal tells you something painful and personal about their marriage. The next morning they are formal and brisk, as though the conversation had never occurred.

- What do you do the following morning, in detail, voice, manner, eye contact?
- What do you do with what you now know?
- What is the trap, and on what timescale does it close?

Case VII · The commission

A contractor you like, and whose work is genuinely excellent, offers you “a small finder's fee, everyone does it” on the works you have been sending him for the past year. He is entirely relaxed about it, and slightly surprised by your hesitation.

- What do you say to him?
- What do you do next, and by when?
- Explain, without moralising, why accepting would end your usefulness to the family.

Case VIII · The colleague

The head of housekeeping, who has been in the house for eleven years, is openly cold to you. She contradicts you in front of junior staff and has twice “forgotten” to pass on a message. The principal asks you, pleasantly, how you are finding the team.

- What do you say to the principal?
- What do you do about the housekeeper, and on what timescale?
- What would the natural, satisfying answer be, and why would it destroy you?

Case IX · The improper instruction

A member of the family, not the principal, asks you to say, if anyone should ask, that they were at the London house on Thursday evening. It is presented lightly, almost as a joke, and it is a very small thing.

- What do you say, in the moment?
- Do you escalate, and to whom?
- Why is the smallness of the request the most dangerous feature of it?

Case X · The withdrawal

Over six weeks, three things have happened: a task you owned has quietly gone to someone else; the principal has begun copying the office on messages that used to come to you alone; and the tone towards you has become notably more polite.

- What is happening?
- What are the two responses that will accelerate it?
- What exactly do you do, and what single question do you ask?

The debriefs

Read only what you have already answered. Each debrief names what the case was testing, gives a defensible answer, and states the general rule.

I · The restaurant

What it tests. Whether you push your own work back onto the principal.

The diary says Rome, Thursday. The preference file says which restaurant, which table, and who dined there in March. The restaurant says it is full. The maître d', whom you have cultivated for two years precisely for an evening like this, says it is not. You hold two times.

You reply once: *"Yes. Thursday, 8pm or 9.30pm, whichever suits. I have kept both."*

Notice that nothing here was improvised. A diary that was read, a file that was kept, a relationship built long before the night it was needed. **Anticipation is not a gift. It is infrastructure.**

THE RULE

The number of questions in your reply is your professional signature. One, or none.

II · The contradiction

What it tests. Whether you understand that signing, deciding and trusting are three different people.

You do not choose a side. You do not quietly proceed. You do not tell the principal that the office has refused, that is not your message to carry, and carrying it makes you the face of a refusal that is not yours.

To the office, in writing, the same day: *"The principal has asked me for this. I want to make sure it is handled correctly, how would you like me to proceed?"*

You have returned the decision to the person whose decision it is, and made yourself the person who handles things correctly.

THE RULE

The staff member who resolves a contradiction alone, by guessing, is blamed by both sides. Always.

III · The journalist

What it tests. Whether you can be flattered into a confirmation. Note the technique: they claim to know already, so that agreeing feels like nothing.

"I'm not able to help with that." Then end the call, courteously, and add no further sentence.

Do not confirm. Do not deny, a denial is information. Do not say “I’ll have to check”, which confirms that you could, and therefore that you are someone worth calling again.

Then tell the house immediately: the number, the time, the exact question asked. Same day, in writing, without drama.

THE RULE

There is no off the record. There never was.

IV · The empty house

What it tests. Whether familiarity dissolves your judgement. It usually does, which is exactly why a real breach almost always wears the face of a friend.

It may be entirely innocent, and it does not matter. Movements and occupancy are **security information**, and they are never yours to give, not to a friend, not to a cousin, not to a supplier who needs to schedule works.

“I honestly don’t keep track of the family’s plans, the office would know.” Warm, unremarkable, closed.

Then you mention it. Not as an accusation, as a fact. Being the person who mentions it is being the person who is trusted.

THE RULE

Security information does not become safe because the room is friendly.

V · The mistake

What it tests. Not the error. Everyone makes the error. What is tested is the ninety minutes that follow it.

First the remedy: what are the real options at 23:00? A later slot, a different aircraft, a repositioning, a commercial alternative, a revised schedule at the far end. You arrive with the problem *and* two solutions and a recommendation, or you are not yet ready to speak.

Then, the same night: *“I made an error with the date. Here is where we are, here are the two ways forward, and I recommend the first.”*

The construction that must never appear is the passive voice. “The booking was made incorrectly” is a lie wearing grammar, and they will hear it as one.

THE RULE

Houses forgive errors. They do not forgive being managed.

VI · The confidence

What it tests. Whether you will mistake a moment of human weakness for an invitation to intimacy.

The next morning you are exactly as you were before: warm, professional, entirely unchanged. You do not soften your voice. You do not offer the sympathetic look. You do not refer to it, then or ever, unless they do.

What you know changes nothing about what you say, and everything about what you anticipate. You protect the calendar. You are gentler with the schedule. You never explain why.

The trap closes slowly, over months, and it closes on you.

THE RULE

Being trusted feels like being chosen. It is not. The confidante becomes a witness, and the witness is moved on.

VII · The commission

What it tests. Whether you understand corruption structurally rather than morally.

To him, without heat: *“I don’t take anything from suppliers, but if there is a trade discount, the household will be glad of it.”* He will not be offended. He has asked before, and been refused before.

Then disclose it to the office the same day, factually, without accusation.

The reason is not that you are pious. It is that the moment you accept, you work for him and not for the family. Every recommendation you make thereafter is compromised, and you will know it, and eventually so will they.

THE RULE

Refuse, disclose, and route every trade advantage back to the household.

VIII · The colleague

What it tests. Whether you will buy short-term relief at the price of your position.

To the principal: *“The team have been very generous with me. We are finding our rhythm.”* Nothing else. It is a test whether or not the principal knows they are administering one, and the natural, satisfying answer, the truthful complaint, destroys you.

To the housekeeper: ask her advice. Publicly, in front of others, on something that genuinely falls within her domain. Take it, and credit her. Repeat this weekly. She does not want your job; she wants to be respected in her own, and she has been here eleven years while you have been here three weeks.

Give it ninety days. If she is still obstructing at ninety days and it materially affects the house, you raise it once, factually, with your line manager, never with the principal.

THE RULE

In a staff conflict there is no winning side. There is only the side that leaves, and it is usually the newest.

IX · The improper instruction

What it tests. Whether you can refuse a small thing charmingly, before it becomes a large thing you cannot refuse.

“I’d rather not, I’m sure you understand.” Warm, immediate, and without argument, moralising or explanation. Do not laugh along, and do not say “this time”.

Yes, you escalate, to the office, factually, the same day. It will feel disproportionate. It is not.

The smallness is the danger. A large improper request is easy to refuse, because it announces itself. A small one establishes a precedent, and the second request will refer to the first: “you did it before.”

THE RULE

A line drawn in calm holds. A line you must find in the moment does not.

X · The withdrawal

What it tests. Whether you can read the household, and whether you can act without either panic or grovelling.

What is happening is withdrawal, and it precedes almost every dismissal in this profession. Politeness up, warmth down, access reduced. It is legible, and at this stage it is still recoverable.

The two responses that accelerate it: **anxiety** (asking repeatedly whether everything is alright, apologising for nothing) and **obsequiousness** (working visibly harder, hovering, over-communicating). Both confirm the suspicion that something is wrong with you.

What you do: ask for ten minutes, and ask one question, *“Is there anything you would like me to be doing differently?”* Then listen without defending yourself, thank them, and change the thing.

THE RULE

The most common reason a household lets someone go is that they never asked.

CHAPTER V

Marking scheme

How your cases will be read, and what to bring

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand the standard against which your judgement is measured.

Prepare the two cases that will make your mentorship session worth its price.

Band	What it looks like
Distinction	A method is visible. The candidate names which of the three levers is at stake, identifies who signs and who decides, and produces an action with at most one easy question remaining. Where they refuse something, they refuse without argument.
Pass	The right instinct, reached without a visible method. The answers are defensible but would not survive an unfamiliar situation. This is where most of you will be, and it is an honourable place to begin.
Rework	The answer pushes work back onto the principal, takes a side, improvises a refusal, or resolves a contradiction by guessing. Any one of these is a rework, however elegant the prose.

What to bring to your session

Not the two cases you found easiest. **The two that made you uncomfortable.** The discomfort is the lesson: it is the precise location of the gap between the person you are and the person this profession requires. We will spend the session there, and nowhere else.

And notice, before you close this document, the single feature common to all ten cases: **in not one of them was the difficulty technical.** Not one required a skill you do not already possess. That is the point of this week, and it is the point of the profession.

ÉMILIE'S NOTE

Reserved. This is where I add what I saw, in my own words.

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